Prologue

November 1989

My dearest sister,

After all these years, this is such a difficult letter to write, but I must try, even if it never reaches you.

You're probably wondering why I never tried to get in touch before. I've waited a long time for my freedom. For too many years, I haven't been able to speak. Now I want to talk until my voice turns hoarse. I have forty-five years of explaining to do.

Let me start by apologizing for my silence. A silence born of regret for what I did.

I had an impossible decision to make, a choice that tore me apart, and I will never forgive myself for what happened. I know that I have hurt the people I love the most—and who loved me.

My only consolation has been the image I've carried all these years of you, Josef and little Katya leading a beautiful, happy life. Tell me about her. I can't believe she's older now than we were when she was born. And not a day goes by when I don't think of you both and wish that things could have been different.

At last, the wall is being pulled down. Come to Berlin. I'll be there the first week of January. We can meet at the place we went to before everything changed. Kaffee Post? I'll be on the corner of Unter den Linden, where it used to be, waiting for you. Please, please come.

I long to see you again, to hold you and tell you everything.

With all my love,